

Implementing Stronger Laws and Enforcement to End Puppy Mills: A Path Forward

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Outline

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Introduction: Stronger laws and enforcement should be implemented, increasing penalties, improving inspections, and pursuing the idea that it is better to adopt than buy, it stops puppy mills from continuing to develop.

- I. Puppy mills keep happening and developing since the punishments and consequences for breaking the law are not strong enough.
 - A. Raising the cost of fines, within time, would make this operation expensive and possibly dangerous, and since this will make puppy mills less profitable and risky for breeders, this could stop the action.
 - B. If the abuse of animals is charged as a criminal offense, this will send an impactful message that animal cruelty is unacceptable and there will be punishment for the ones who commit the actions.
 - C. The idea of bigger penalties, such as longer prison sentences, will make breeders think twice and visualize that the consequences will be serious, which will prevent them from breaking the law.
 - D. Some believe stronger penalties won't stop puppy mills because breeders may ignore the risks, and tougher laws could be hard to enforce, with education and awareness being a better option.
- II. In some states, laws are in place to stop puppy mills, yet the problem is that they are not serious and enforced enough, which allows breeders to keep puppy mills running.
 - A. For breeders to not hide from the law, the government should hire more inspectors and give them adequate training that would help catch puppy mills.

- B. In order to track abusive breeders and make sure they don't start a new organization when they get caught, keeping a national list of breeders will help find this out.
 - C. Better communication and collaboration between police and animal protection groups will help shut down puppy mills faster when violations are found.
 - D. Some argue that better inspections and enforcement may be too costly and slow and that stricter laws and public awareness could be more effective in preventing puppy mills.
- III. Educating and encouraging people to adopt dogs from shelters will help reduce the demand for puppies bred in poor conditions.
- A. Public and social media awareness campaigns will help people understand the horrible and difficult conditions dogs have to live in, and since the truth will be shown, people are likely to not support these organizations.
 - B. Offering rewards to people, such as tax breaks or discounts for adoption from shelters, will encourage people to adopt rather than buy dogs.
 - C. Teaching and showing people the example of responsible breeders will help them make better choices by the time they have a pet, and they will support healthy organizations.
 - D. Some believe promoting adoption won't reduce demand because people may still prefer to buy puppies for convenience or breed preferences and that rewards like tax breaks won't work, so stronger laws are a better solution.

Conclusion: In order to stop the cruelty of puppy mills, stronger laws, better enforcement, and raising awareness are needed.

Implementing Stronger Laws and Enforcement to End Puppy Mills: A Path Forward

Many pet stores and online sellers present a false, idealized image of pets, but in reality, dogs suffer in unimaginable, painful conditions just to make money. Puppy mills are large breeding operations where dogs, mostly females, are kept in small cages and are forced to have constant litters until they die from harsh conditions or old age. These dogs live surrounded by dirt, extreme temperatures, overcrowding, food placed out of reach, and a complete lack of attention. The dogs are often not given adequate medical care, and many are suffering from infections, parasites, and malnutrition. All of this occurs because of human avarice, as breeders care only about profit and fail to care for the animal's well-being. Some states have laws designed to stop puppy mills, but these laws are often weak and poorly enforced. As a result, puppy mills continue to thrive, often in the shadows, where violations go unnoticed. In order to stop puppy mills from continuing to develop stronger laws, better enforcement, and a shift in public attitudes toward adoption rather than purchasing puppies should be implemented. A multi-pronged approach that includes legal reform, better inspections, and widespread public education could significantly control the inhumane practices associated with puppy mills.

Firstly, one of the most effective ways to combat puppy mills is by increasing penalties for those who operate these inhumane facilities. Currently, fines and imprisonment for violations of animal welfare laws are not substantial enough to discourage breeders from running puppy mills. In many cases, the fines are insignificant compared to the huge profits made by selling puppies to unsuspecting buyers. If the penalties were more severe, operating a puppy mill would become a much riskier and costlier business. As the Humane Society of the United States (2020) states, "Puppy mills are financially motivated, and as the penalties for animal abuse increase, the profit margins of these breeders go down." By raising fines and extending sentences, it can make

it much harder for breeders to continue these operations. Even a few high-profile cases that result in long prison sentences and large fines could send a strong message that animal cruelty will not be tolerated, forcing others to reconsider their actions. If animal cruelty were treated as a serious felony, it would send a clear message that this behavior would not be tolerated in our society, and people would be less inclined to risk running these mills. A substantial increase in penalties would make it much more likely that offenders would face severe consequences, warning future breeders from engaging in such practices. Moreover, making animal cruelty a felony would allow for harsher sentences, possibly including long-term prison terms and the permanent revocation of any breeding licenses. This would result in a much stronger obstacle effect.

Critics often argue that increasing penalties would be ineffective without improved enforcement and inspections. They claim that the high cost of inspections and law enforcement might outbalance the benefits, especially given the demands on local resources. However, it is important to note that without tough enforcement, even the strongest penalties will have little impediment effect. As People for the Ethical Treatment of Animals or PETA (2021) states, "The lack of enough inspectors and oversight leads to widespread abuse in many facilities, as inspections are often inconsistent and penalties are not enforced." Effective inspections ensure that laws are followed, allowing authorities to shut down puppy mills before they can grow. In states where inspections are performed regularly and thoroughly, violations are quickly identified, and the mills can be forced to close. Without regular inspections, it is nearly impossible to ensure that laws are being followed, and that the puppies continue to live in dirty, dangerous conditions. Hiring more inspectors and establishing a national registry of breeders could make enforcement more efficient and reduce the chances of violators slipping through the cracks. Having a national registry could also help prevent breeders who have been shut down for

violations from simply relocating and opening a new puppy mill elsewhere. Making inspections more frequent and more rigorous, will ensure that all puppy mills are held accountable for their actions.

Secondly, beyond stricter penalties, improving the inspection process is a critical element in the fight against puppy mills. The lack of enough inspectors often allows these operations to continue unchecked, sometimes for years, with no consequences. With more inspectors, authorities would be able to perform meticulous and regular checks on puppy mills to ensure that the animals' living conditions comply with animal welfare standards. These inspections would check for violations of basic animal rights, such as the provision of adequate food, clean water, and proper shelter. Additionally, inspectors would be able to evaluate the medical care provided to the animals and make sure that any sick or injured animals receive treatment. According to People for the Ethical Treatment of Animals or PETA, (2021), "The lack of enough inspectors and oversight leads to widespread abuse in many facilities, as inspections are often inconsistent and penalties are not enforced." This lack of supervision allows puppy mills to flourish without fear of counterattack. Inadequate inspections often allow violators to operate for extended periods before being caught, contributing to ongoing animal suffering. Establishing a national registry would help track violators, preventing them from reopening operations under new names or in different locations. These measures would improve the chances of catching violators early, reducing the scale of the abuse, and helping to remove harmful breeders from the industry altogether.

While some critics argue that inspections would be too costly and time-consuming, the long-term savings make such an investment worthwhile. Without proper inspections, problems can escalate, leading to larger-scale abuse and the need for expensive rescues and interventions.

Animal cruelty on such a large scale requires significant resources to undo, and it can take years to rehabilitate the dogs that have been abused in puppy mills. By identifying issues early, inspections can prevent these situations from developing into more significant problems. For example, regular inspections could catch diseases like kennel cough, parvovirus, and other infections before they spread to other animals in the mill, reducing the need for costly medical treatments. Similarly, early detection of overcrowding or inadequate facilities could lead to the immediate closure of a facility, reducing the number of animals that suffer. Investing in more inspectors and more frequent checks could save money in the long run by stopping puppy mills before they can grow or spread. Furthermore, having a national registry of breeders and puppy mills would allow for better tracking and coordination among different states, making it harder for breeders to evade enforcement. This would help to reduce the spread of puppy mills and stop breeders from exploiting gaps in state laws.

Thirdly, public awareness campaigns are another key component in reducing the demand for puppies from puppy mills. Many people purchase puppies from breeders without fully understanding the conditions the animals are subjected to. Education through social media and other public platforms can help change this. As Humane Society International (2022) reports, "Social media platforms and public awareness campaigns are excellent tools in educating individuals on the horrors of puppy mills." By showcasing the inhumane treatment of dogs in these facilities, these campaigns can encourage potential pet owners to consider adoption over buying. Awareness campaigns can take many forms, including viral videos, social media posts, documentaries, and public service announcements. These efforts can bring attention to the abuse occurring in puppy mills and encourage consumers to make more informed choices. Once the public is more aware of the issues with puppy mills, they will be more likely to adopt pets from

shelters instead of purchasing puppies from breeders. In addition to awareness, offering motivation like tax breaks or discounts on pet supplies for those who adopt could further encourage people to choose adoption as an alternative. These stimulants could lower the financial barrier to adopting a pet and make it more attractive to people who might otherwise consider purchasing a puppy from a breeder. Many successful adoption campaigns, such as the "Adopt, Don't Shop" movement, have already shown that public awareness can lead to a significant shift in consumer behavior.

Ms. Ayda Sandoval, a certified professional dog trainer and my mentor, emphasizes the inhumane nature of puppy mills. She explains, "It is a place where people put dogs in cages all their lives, and they are very mistreated and malnourished. They have no freedom, and most of the dogs' lives are just breeding, which is a big issue." The constant cycle of breeding in puppy mills contributes to overpopulation, as the dogs often live in conditions that lead to malnourishment and illness. Sandoval also notes, "Lack of education really, people who are money-making and people want to make money the easy way out... there has to be stronger laws for that." Sandoval's perspective highlights the need for better awareness, stricter laws, and more consistent enforcement to address the root causes of the puppy mill problem. Furthermore, she advocates for federal mandates that could ensure uniform standards across the country, as laws vary greatly from state to state. "It would be nice to have a federal mandate or have the whole United States operate under the same rules," she adds. This would ensure that all breeders are held to the same high standards, no matter where they operate. Creating a federal mandate would also prevent breeders from simply relocating their operations to states with weaker laws, allowing for a more consistent and unified approach to combating puppy mills nationwide.

Some critics argue that promoting adoption may not significantly reduce the demand for puppies from breeders. They contend that many people prefer specific breeds and will continue purchasing from breeders, even after learning about the conditions in puppy mills. However, this argument overlooks the potential impact of public education. Adoption campaigns can and do change perceptions and shift public preferences. As studies have shown, "Adoption campaigns can change perceptions and shift public preferences towards rescue pets" (Humane Society, 2022). Critics may also argue that offering motivation like tax breaks or discounts won't affect people's preferences. However, studies suggest that such incentives have been successful in increasing adoption rates. Furthermore, by providing more exposure to the positive aspects of adoption, including the joy of saving a dog from a shelter, people are more likely to choose adoption over purchasing from breeders. While breed preferences are important for some pet owners, providing people with more information about the benefits of adoption, combined with incentives can reduce the demand for puppies bred in mills. Moreover, as the public becomes more aware of the horrors of puppy mills, breeders may find it more difficult to sell their puppies, as consumers may begin to prefer adopting over purchasing from breeders.

In conclusion, the cruelty continued by puppy mills can only be effectively addressed through a combination of stronger penalties, better enforcement of existing laws, and a shift in public attitudes toward adoption rather than buying puppies. While some may believe that education alone can solve the problem, evidence shows that without stricter laws and more consistent enforcement, puppy mills will continue to thrive. The implementation of a national registry, better inspections, and a focus on adoption can reduce the demand for puppies from breeders, thereby decreasing the profitability of puppy mills. By working together, these strategies can end the cycle of animal suffering and help protect future generations of dogs. With

stronger regulations, better oversight, and a shift in public attitudes, we can begin to eliminate the prevalence of puppy mills, reducing the suffering of countless dogs, and promoting the humane treatment of animals across the country.

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